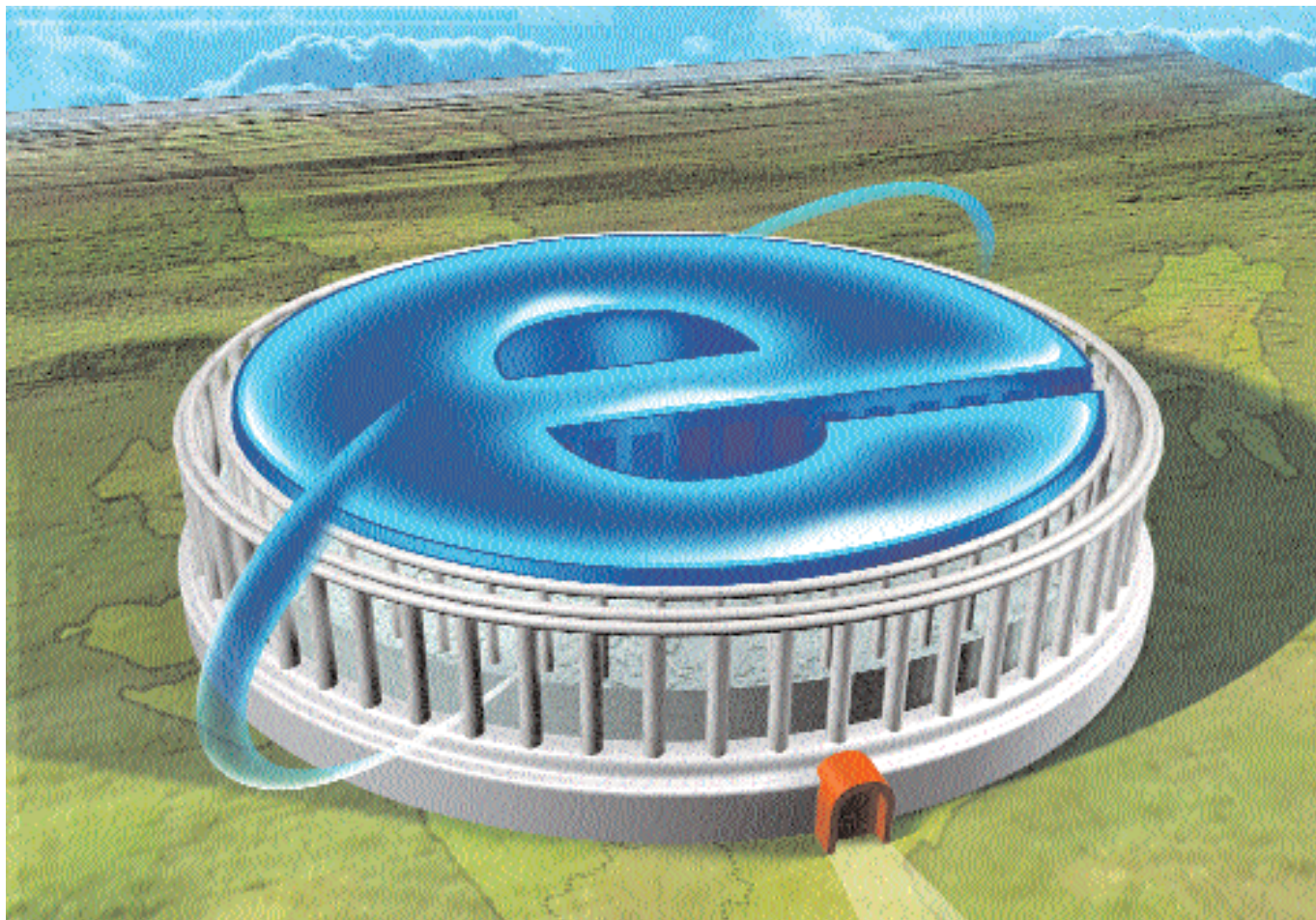


The Challenges of e-governance



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It was the wheel that began it all—technologies that have a fundamental impact on human society. The steam engine, electricity, the car, the airplane, the television, the phone—tools we cannot think of existing without.

But surely, if there has been one advancement in human endeavour that has overshadowed all others in the last decade and a half, it is information technology. Arguably, it is also the only development that has touched so many lives in so little time.

The dotcom boom and bust may have earned the Internet a bad name, but the initial experimentation with associated business models and democratisation of technology during the dotcom boom provided a deep knowledge base to leverage the Internet for the greater good.

Consider this: The bust actually paved the way

for an evolved vision—growth accompanied and tempered by ground reality. What this meant was that corporates adopted the Internet to not only enhance productivity, but also to develop innovative business models.

Once the corporate world adopts this model, governments have to take it up too under pressure to perform in a democratic setup. Which naturally means that governments will have to look into issues concerning people, processes and technology. In the not-so-distant future, our public administration system could well have an online interface to liaise with people.

An online government implies a single point of access to all public information, and greater citizen interaction with the administration through Internet-based services. It also helps actualise the potential to streamline relationships between gov-

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